Library of Congress Subject Authority Records

H 40

Table of Contents

A. Background 1

B. Recent revisions 1

C. Characteristics of subject authority records 2

C.1. Records for approved headings 2

C.2. Records for newly proposed headings 2

C.3. Records for headings being updated 2

D. Assigning valid headings as subjects 2

E. Non-authoritative subject heading sources 3

Revision history 3

A. Background

Online subject authority records in Classification Web Plus and the LC Database take precedence over all printed products as authority for the non-free-floating elements of subject headings. Additionally, subdivision authority records have been created to control the more than 3,500 free-floating subdivisions. These records, used in conjunction with name authority records in the LC Database and the lists of free-floating subdivisions and other elements in the *Subject Headings Manual*, constitute final authority for the assignment of subject headings.

A copy of each subject authority record in Classification Web Plus also resides in the LC Database. In addition to being the most authoritative list of subject headings, Classification Web Plus is also used for products such as the Subject Headings Tentative Lists and Library of Congress Subject Headings, which was published annually in print form until 2013. LCSH is now available as free PDF files on the Acquisitions and Bibliographic Access website.

B. Recent revisions

2026-04: Updated template.

C. Characteristics of subject authority records

C.1. Records for approved headings

An existing heading that is approved and valid for use is represented in Classification Web Plus and the LC Database by a single authority record with a record ID number in the 010 field having the prefix **sh**. In the Classification Web Plus browse display, approved headings appear in black.

C.2. Records for newly proposed headings

Proposed headings reside in the Subject Heading Proposal System, which is a module of Classification Web Plus. The record ID number in the 010 field has the prefix **sp**. The heading is not valid for use until it has been approved during the editorial process. Once the Policy, Training, and Cooperative Programs Division has assigned the proposal to a tentative list, the list number can be found in the 907 $t subfield of the MARC authority record in the Subject Heading Proposal System. In the Classification Web Plus browse display, newly proposed headings appear in green.

Example:

```
Proposal assigned to the December 2024 list:
   907 ## $a 2412
```

C.3. Records for headings being updated

An existing heading that is being changed in any way is represented in the Subject Heading Proposal System by two authority records, one having a record ID number with the prefix **sh** in the 010 field, and the other having the same record ID number but with the prefix **sp**. In order to determine the nature of the update being performed, it is necessary to compare the “sh” record with its “sp” counterpart. Once the Policy, Training, and Cooperative Programs Division has assigned the proposal to a tentative list, the list number can be found in the 907 $t subfield of the MARC authority record in the Subject Heading Proposal System. In the Classification Web Plus browse display, change proposal headings appear in orange-brown.

D. Assigning valid headings as subjects

Before assigning a subject heading to a work being cataloged, ascertain that either

1. it is an RDA name heading represented by a name authority record in the LC Database (cf. H 430); or
2. it is represented in the LC Database or in Classification Web by a single subject authority record that has an 010 field with an **sh** record number; or

3. if it is represented in the Subject Heading Proposal System by two subject authority records one of which has an 010 field with an **sp** record number, the change being made is to a field other than the 1XX field; or
4. it is authorized by free-floating provisions (cf. H 362 for free-floating terms and phrases, H 1090 for multiple subdivisions, and H 1095-H 1200 for free-floating subdivisions).

Do not assign headings that have both “sh” and “sp” records unless the proposed change is in a field other than the 1XX field, that is, unless the heading itself is unaffected by the change.

E. Non-authoritative subject heading sources

The following sources, although useful tools for reference purposes, may not be treated as authority for the assignment of a subject heading:

- Bibliographic records in the LC Database
- Tentative lists of new subject heading proposals (including those proposals marked (A)).

Revision history

2026-04: Updated template.